

RICHARD OKONICHA

✉ richardokonicha@gmail.com in/richardokonicha github.com/richardokonicha

SUMMARY

Solutions Architect and **Senior Engineer** with experience engineering enterprise **software**, bare-metal **cloud** infrastructure, and distributed **AI** systems. I bring an extensive background as an individual project contributor, technical lead, and technical consultant. I'm adept at planning, solving complex technical problems, and standing in front of enterprise clients to bridge deep engineering depth with clear **business value**, while driving **team effort** with clear **communication** and championing good company **culture** and values.

I am focused on continuous career growth and am actively seeking challenging opportunities to scale my leadership and impact, and to express passion in my work.

EXPERIENCE

Lead Systems Architect

Fugoku Cloud

October 2025 - Present, Remote

- Architected sovereign AI cloud platform on bare-metal OpenStack with GPU/TPU compute fabric; engineered LLM gateway with custom model-routing, LiteLLM, and Helicone analytics.
- Consulting and talking to customers, offering value first approach to services.
- Built an orchestration layer with SkyPilot, automated failover, and a browser-based terminal (xterm.js).
- Reduced inference latency from 300ms+ (EU) to <50ms (Lagos); cut tenant operational costs by 65% via microservices migration.
- **Stack:** OpenStack, SkyPilot, LiteLLM, Helicone, K3s, Python, Go, GPU/TPU Orchestration, Terraform.

Senior Infrastructure Engineer

Inference Cloud

September 2024 - November 2025, Switzerland

- Led enterprise application architecture for Swiss AI writing platform with strict multi-tenant isolation.
- Served as the core technical liaison bridging high-level stakeholder business goals with engineering execution.
- Resolved high-concurrency race condition in async request queue, eliminating production 500 errors; redesigned request pipeline for enterprise traffic spikes.
- **Stack:** Python, Tenant Isolation, High-Concurrency Queues, Docker, Cloud Infrastructure.

Senior Engineer - Storefront

Swell

January 2022 - August 2024, San Francisco, CA Remote

- Owned the core **storefront theme engine** and the origin theme and spearheaded feature development for a next-generation, high-scale enterprise SaaS platform in development.
- Designed a resilient Stripe payment architecture processing thousands of concurrent global transactions daily.
- Refactored the checkout pipeline to eliminate distributed state race conditions, resolving duplicate transaction charge bugs.
- Built a containerized client-onboarding orchestration template, reducing tenant setup time from several days to under two hours.
- Managed release cycle for our core themes including origin theme and horizon, published changelogs and documentation helping clients update their individual stores to latest.
- **Stack:** Kubernetes, PostgreSQL, Redis, Vue.js, TypeScript, Node.js, MongoDB.

Senior Engineer & Architect

Cardagraph

December 2020 - December 2022, Salt Lake City, UT Remote

- Designed production ML pipelines forecasting software delivery timelines; built a predictive analytics engine, reducing forecast error by 30%.
- Architected full-stack interfaces and integrated the ML engine into client dashboards via high-performance REST APIs.
- Designed the UI for the analytics platform and its dashboards; this project was ahead of its time before frontier AI models, utilizing **primitive ML** inference and mathematical formulas to create insights.
- **Stack:** Python, React.js, Docker, PostgreSQL, REST APIs, Feature Engineering

Backend Engineer

OHIOH / Linux Foundation Public Health

March 2020 - November 2020, Germany Remote

- Built a high-throughput REST API backend for a large-scale contact-tracing application (Linux Foundation COVID hackathon).
- Sponsored by IBM & Linux Foundation.
- Isolated and patched a critical memory leak in the upstream MongoDB driver causing system degradation under peak traffic loads.
- Optimized database query paths and connection pooling to ensure uninterrupted availability during rapid regional scale-ups.
- **Stack:** Django, REST API, OpenAPI/Swagger 3.0, MongoDB, Docker.

Technical Lead

eHealth4Everyone

March 2018 - February 2020, Abuja, Nigeria On-site

- Led team of 6 engineers building health data systems for government clients.
- Designed OpenHisa health insurance system deployed across 12 Nigerian states; engineered MSDAT platform (Gates Foundation) serving 10,000+ users.
- Refactored legacy database paths, eliminating N+1 query patterns to reduce critical API latencies by 40%.
- Stack: Python, Django, React.js, MongoDB, PostgreSQL, Docker, Kubernetes, Traefik.

Software Engineer & Founder

Swedish Accelerator (Roar Hub)

May 2016 – August 2018, Nigeria On-site

- Selected for international accelerator focused on agile development and VC fundraising.
- Architected and shipped multiple MVPs from scratch in Python and JavaScript under constrained timelines.
- Stack: Python, JavaScript, Shell Scripting, MVP Architecture.

EDUCATION

B.Eng. in Mechanical Engineering

University of Nigeria, Nsukka

- Focus: Systems Architecture & Design * Autonomous Robotics * Computational Modeling

Advanced Computer Programming

Harvard University

- CS50 * Algorithms * File Systems * Automation * Cloud * Machine Learning

INVOLVEMENT

AI Integrations Expert (Open Source)

Remote • MindsDB (Parttime) • September 2025 – Present

- **Core Engineering:** Built and maintained critical core AI integrations enabling developers to seamlessly query LLMs via standard SQL workflows, including the Postgres, Elasticsearch, Teams teams connector and adding MCP support for agents.
- **Pipeline Automation:** Collaborated directly with the core engineering team on processes, production-grade model serving frameworks and automated fine-tuning pipelines.
- *Stack:* Python, SQL, MindsDB Core, Model Serving, LLM Integrations

Principal Software and Cloud Architect & AI Consultant

Remote (Part-Time) • Independent Practice/Consultant • June 2024 – Present

- Enterprise Advisory: Advise global startups and enterprise clients on sovereign cloud strategy, high-performance **GPU/TPU cluster** provisioning, and private cloud orchestration.
- **AI365Services** (Contract): Architected AI adoption strategies for enterprise transition to **agentic systems**; implemented **Turbo Quant** quantization on **self-hosted LLMs**, optimizing VRAM and inference throughput thus cutting cost without losing advantage, built **secure AI Agent framework** for enterprise and partook in client **sales calls** and supported strategy development effort across board.
- Enterprise Architecture & Security: Optimized containerized IAM deployments for **Authentik Security (Open Source)** and engineered secure infrastructure for AI code-generation agents via **OpenHands**.
- Technical Leadership: **Mentored** and advised 100+ developers, engineering managers, and technical leaders on scaling distributed systems and complex cloud architectures via Codementor.
- Stack: Private Cloud Strategy, High-Performance GPU Orchestration, Turbo Quant, IAM, Enterprise Architecture AI Integrations.

GDG Tech Community Leader

Asaba • Google Developers Community • January 2021 – December 2023

- Moved to my hometown for a brief period and couldn't find a tech community. Met a couple of techies at the gym, had a good chat, and decided to start a new Google Developers Chapter for Asaba, Delta State. (I had prior experience with tech hackathons, events and GDG communities from my time at the university and my sister is a GDG expert so I had her help too)
 - Became a Co-lead, built a core team, and consolidated our efforts in planning, organization, and fundraising for the event.
 - Personally met with a number of local tech firm CEOs and a few regional bank managers, selling the dream of building a thriving tech community and pitching to them a future hiring pool of professionals.
 - Personally hosted the first, very thrilling hackathon a few weeks before the community debut at the Google Developers Festival event, drawing over 250 people in attendance and streaming the entire event live on YouTube.
 - Co-hosted the official debut festival that December, securing an attendance of over 700 community members.
 - Left Asaba in 2023, handing over all operational responsibilities to members of the leadership team.
 - The Asaba chapter now independently runs about 4 tech events every year, was gifted a physical coworking space by the Delta State Government called DSIHUB, and has achieved official government and Google worldwide acknowledgment and financial support.
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